



galyn wilkins

Return of the Giants

No matter that the Rangers have sometimes been accused of operating a baseball franchise like the Italians operated a war. Forgive them their administrative trespasses, their fielding errors. Forget the price increases.

Nay, they deserve the Old-Timers Humanitarian Award and the lasting debt of the Old Box Score Readers' Assn. Praise 'em, they have resurrected The Giants, a lost civilization.

The Giants, or at least a shred of them will parade through Arlington Stadium Saturday evening and who cares if Bobby Thomson's short, lethal swing cannot be restored? Who cares if the field will be full of bouncing bellys and sagging jowls and creaking arms?

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Phenom named Clint

The Giants are back. Who knows where they've gone since Willie Mays' fast legs and quick batting stroke turned to stone? Since Sal Maglie last knocked down a hitter? Since Johnny Antonelli was the Prince of Broadway?

Someone said the Giants are hanging out on a spit of land near San Francisco, but they hardly attract any attention these days. Had a good third sacker a number of years ago named Jim Davenport who won a string of Gold Gloves. Had a tricky pitcher named Juan Marichal who threw his spikes in a hitter's face and then came in low and hard. Had an outfielder named Bobby Bonds who was gonna be another Mel Ott. But he moved on. They all moved on.

Funny about the Giants, if you're up on your baseball lore, but they always had a kid who was gonna be another Mel Ott.

There was the Texas kid named Clint Hartung who came after the war. For a service team, he had hit .556 and threw no-hitters every day. The Giants couldn't wait to turn him loose on the National League.

A year later in spring training he was struggling to make the team. A columnist for a New York paper wrote of Hartung's difficulties and heartbreak.

The Giants broke camp and moved through the midwest on a exhibition tour. Everywhere they stopped, the Hartung story would be reprinted in the local journal.

Hartung had seen the piece maybe 20 times and was sick of it. Finally, in an Oklahoma City hotel lobby he grabbed the New York writer by the lapels and shouted, "When the hell you gonna stop writing that column about me?"

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Andy burned out

There was another immortal of an earlier time, an inspiration of the team's famous manager, John McGraw. For years he dreamed of having a Jewish star as a lure for New York's growing Jewish population.

Into his arms came Andy Cohen. The Giants made room for this new wonder by trading Rogers Hornsby to Boston. His first game, Cohen won the game with a double.

The next year, Cohen was gone. The legend is that Jewish society distracted him with so many invitations he could no longer concentrate on baseball. As Cohen went to the minors, Hornsby hit .387 for Boston.

The Giants always had a way of disappearing.